

Live Voice-AI Companionship in Outdoor Recreation

A Market Opportunity Assessment

July 2026

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1. Executive Summary

This market sits at the intersection of two independently fast-growing markets — outdoor recreation and voice AI companionship — at a moment when the outdoor participant base is at a record high but per-person engagement frequency is declining. Both secondary research and primary user testing point in the same direction: the demand exists, the audience is large and growing, and a specific product position this report identifies as open — a live, in-ear, conversational companion active during the activity itself — does not appear to be held by any of the competitors reviewed for this report.

183.2 million — Americans participated in outdoor recreation in 2025 — a record high, up nearly 30 million since 2019.^[1]

61.2% positive intent — of 201 surveyed users said they would definitely or probably use a product like this, on a cold concept pitch with no brand awareness.

No direct competitor identified — in the “live, real-time, conversational” quadrant among the six platforms reviewed — each was either static (AllTrails, audio-tour apps) or reactive/post-activity (Strava, Fitbit, Outside's Scout). This is based on a limited competitive scan, not an exhaustive market map.^[3,4,13,16,17]

Three findings anchor the rest of this report:

- Market pull, not push. Outdoor participation is growing across nearly every demographic — including two structurally under-served, fast-growing segments (adults 65+ and solo explorers) — while the specific behavior of going out often is declining, pointing to a friction problem a companion product is positioned to solve, not a demand problem.
- The gap looks structural, not incremental. Each of the major fitness and outdoor tech platforms we reviewed (Strava, Fitbit/Garmin, and outdoor media itself) has independently moved toward conversational AI in the last 12 months — a meaningful validation signal — but each has built it as a pre-trip planner or post-activity analyst. None of the platforms reviewed operate live, during the activity.
- Primary research is directionally consistent with the secondary data. Surveyed users independently described a problem that lines up with the market data — 73.6% explore mostly alone, 51.7% feel curious about their surroundings regularly, and 45.8% say that curiosity typically goes unmet — without being prompted toward that conclusion.

2. Market Opportunity

The addressable market for this product category is best understood as the overlap of three independently large and growing markets: outdoor recreation participation, the voice AI / AI-companion category, and the solo-exploration behavioral segment that cuts across both.

2.1 Outdoor recreation: a record, growing base

- US outdoor recreation participation reached 183.2 million people in 2025 (59% of Americans age 6+), up nearly 30 million since 2019.^[1]
- Walking, hiking, fishing, camping, bicycling, and running are the accessible “gateway” activities driving growth — each gained an average of 2.1 million new participants in the latest reporting year, with hiking alone reaching roughly 63 million U.S. participants in 2024 — squarely overlapping this product category's core use case.^[1,2]
- Two segments are growing fastest: adults 65+ (senior participation +7.4% year-over-year in 2025, the fastest of any age group, with 23.1 million participants born before 1959 in 2024 alone) and households with children (roughly two-thirds now participate in outdoor activities).^[1,2]
- The friction point: while the participant base keeps expanding, annual outing frequency is declining — a motivation/engagement gap, not a demand gap, and exactly the gap a companion product is positioned to close.

[1]

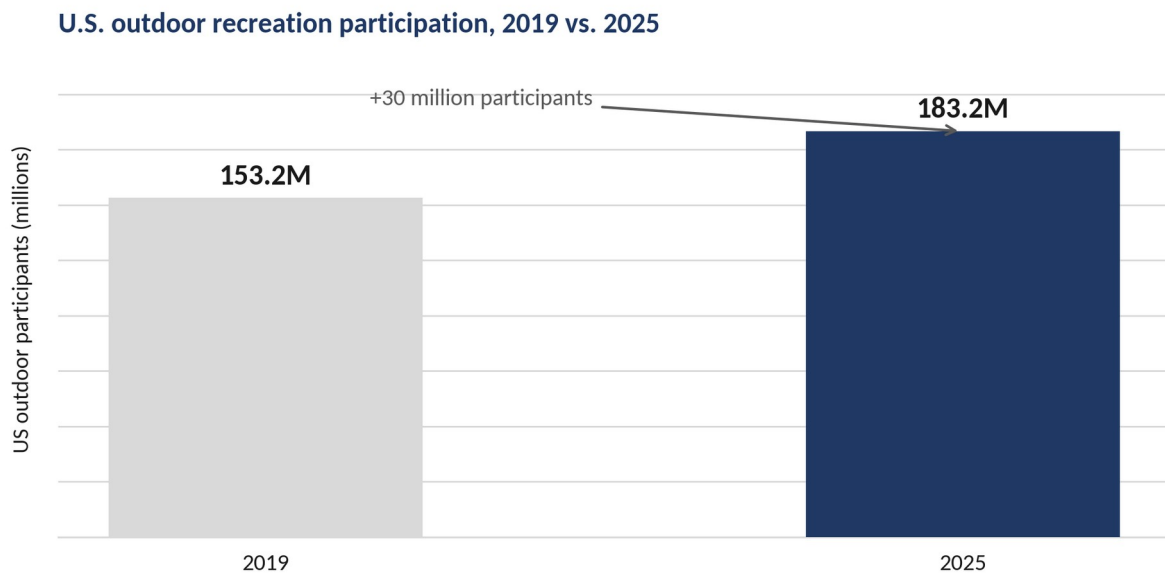


Figure 1. U.S. outdoor recreation participants, 2019 vs. 2025. Source: Outdoor Industry Association / Outdoor Foundation.

2.2 Voice AI & AI companionship: the technology tailwind

- The global voice AI companion market was valued at \$4.39B in 2025 and is projected to reach \$42.82B by 2033 (31.4% CAGR, 2026–2033). A broader-scoped estimate puts 2025 at \$12.37B growing to \$63.38B by 2035 (17.75% CAGR) — estimates vary by definition, but all point sharply upward.^[7,8]
- Individual consumers are the largest single end-user segment at 55.5% of the market, driven by everyday hands-free use cases — exactly the model considered in this report.^[7]
- The adjacent voice-recognition market (a broader category including on-device and enterprise applications) was valued at \$18.4B in 2025 and is projected to reach \$61.7B by 2031 (22.4% CAGR); the narrower AI voice agents segment is growing even faster, from \$2.54B (2025) to \$35.24B by 2033 (39% CAGR).^[25]

Global voice AI companion market size

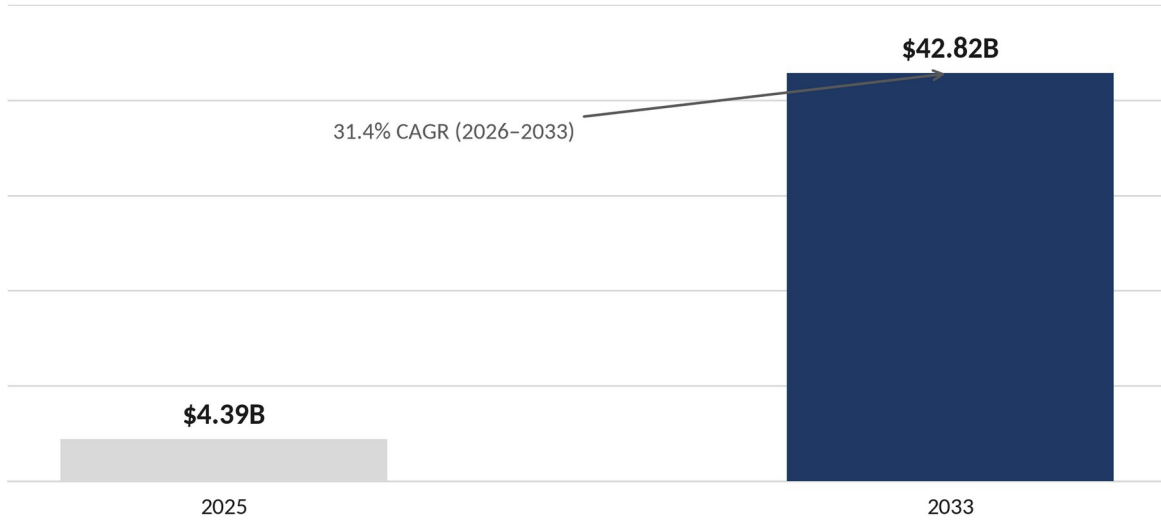


Figure 2. Global voice AI companion market size, 2025 vs. 2033 (CAGR 31.4%). Source: industry market-sizing reports, 2025–2026.

2.3 Solo exploration: a fast-growing behavioral segment

- The global solo travel market was valued at ~\$549.78B in 2025, projected to reach \$627.28B in 2026 and ~\$1.6T by 2033 (14.6% CAGR). Bookings are up 24% since 2019, and related search interest has more than quadrupled since 2016.^[9,10]
- 47% of solo travelers engage in adventure activities — hiking, cycling, diving — directly overlapping this product category's use case.^[9]
- Solo exploration is often circumstantial, not purely elective: 53% of women cite not having a travel companion as a reason for going solo, and women make up an estimated 54–85% of solo travelers depending on the source — reinforcing demand for a “companion” framing rather than a pure utility framing.^[9,10]

3. Problem Validation

Beyond market size, three independent data threads support the idea that the specific problem this product category targets — unmet curiosity, low motivation, and loneliness/safety concern while exploring — is real, felt, and not yet well addressed.

3.1 Mental health has reframed outdoor time as necessity, not leisure

- Peer-reviewed research links time in green and blue outdoor spaces to measurable improvements in physical, mental, and physiological health among older adults specifically, including better self-rated health with longer park stays.^[22]
- A nationally representative U.S. study during COVID-19 found outdoor activity participation was strongly associated with better subjective wellbeing even as both outdoor participation and wellbeing broadly declined during the pandemic — evidence that outdoor time functions as a coping mechanism, not just recreation.^[24]
- Young adults (18–24) are increasingly going outdoors specifically to counter digital burnout, part of a broader “healthmaxxing” wellness trend — suggesting the necessity framing is already emerging organically among users themselves, rather than needing to be imposed.^[23]

3.2 Loneliness and safety are explicit, stated barriers

- 49% of solo travelers report worrying about loneliness while exploring alone.^[11]
- 64% of solo female travelers report worrying about their own safety while traveling alone — a fear that eases with experience but remains at 52% even among women who have taken 10+ solo trips, and reaches 65% among women who have never traveled solo but are considering it.^[12]
- *[Placeholder — to be completed before publication: 2–3 verbatim, permalinked quotes from r/hiking, r/CampingandHiking, r/solotravel, or r/GetOutside illustrating the loneliness/safety theme in users' own words. Repeated search attempts could not reliably retrieve real posts for this revision, and no quotes have been generated or inferred to fill this gap — see Section 8 for the sourcing recommendation.]*
- These are not abstract concerns — they describe the exact moments (uncertainty, disorientation, wanting a second “presence”) a live conversational companion is designed to soften.

3.3 Existing platforms show the appetite but not the product

- AllTrails' active base has grown from 10 million (2019) to more than 95 million users (March 2026) — evidence that a large audience will adopt outdoor-companion software at scale.^[3]
- Independent analysis has described AllTrails' social/community layer as comparatively weak (“like a barren desert” next to Strava, in one analyst's words), which may limit organic word-of-mouth growth; the same analysis cites an average of ~6 hikes per year for US hikers, a low frequency that could make a pure trail-database subscription harder to justify on its own.^[5]
- Independent reporting has also raised real user trust concerns: AllTrails' hiking data has been found to be public and findable on Google by default, which in one documented case exposed the location data of a senior White House official — an opening for privacy-forward positioning, though the practical effect on AllTrails' own growth isn't something this report can quantify.^[6]

4. Competitive Landscape

This section reviews six named platforms that overlap with this product category — not an exhaustive market scan. Among the six, none combine real-time delivery with genuine conversational depth: the group splits between static/data-first tools without a voice layer, and AI-conversational tools that operate only before or after the activity.

[3,4,5,6,13,14,15,16,17,18]

Product	What it does	Real-time?	Conversational AI?	Key gap
AllTrails	Trail discovery, tracking, community reviews	Partial (tracking only)	No — adding ML personalization, no live voice	No narration; weak social layer; documented privacy concerns
VoiceMap / GPSmyCity	Pre-recorded audio tours	Scripted, not live	No	Fixed tours only, city-limited, no live Q&A or sensor awareness
Strava (Athlete Intelligence + AI connector)	Post-activity data analysis	No — after the fact	Yes, but reactive / read-only	Doesn't operate during the activity
Outside's "Scout"	AI trip-planning chatbot	No — pre-trip only	Yes	Planning tool, not an in-activity companion
Fitbit Personal Health Coach	LLM-generated workout plans	No — before/after	Yes	Plan generation, not live narration
(Open position)	Live voice AI companion during the activity	Yes, continuous	Yes, fully conversational	Not observed among the competitors reviewed

Positioning of the six platforms reviewed

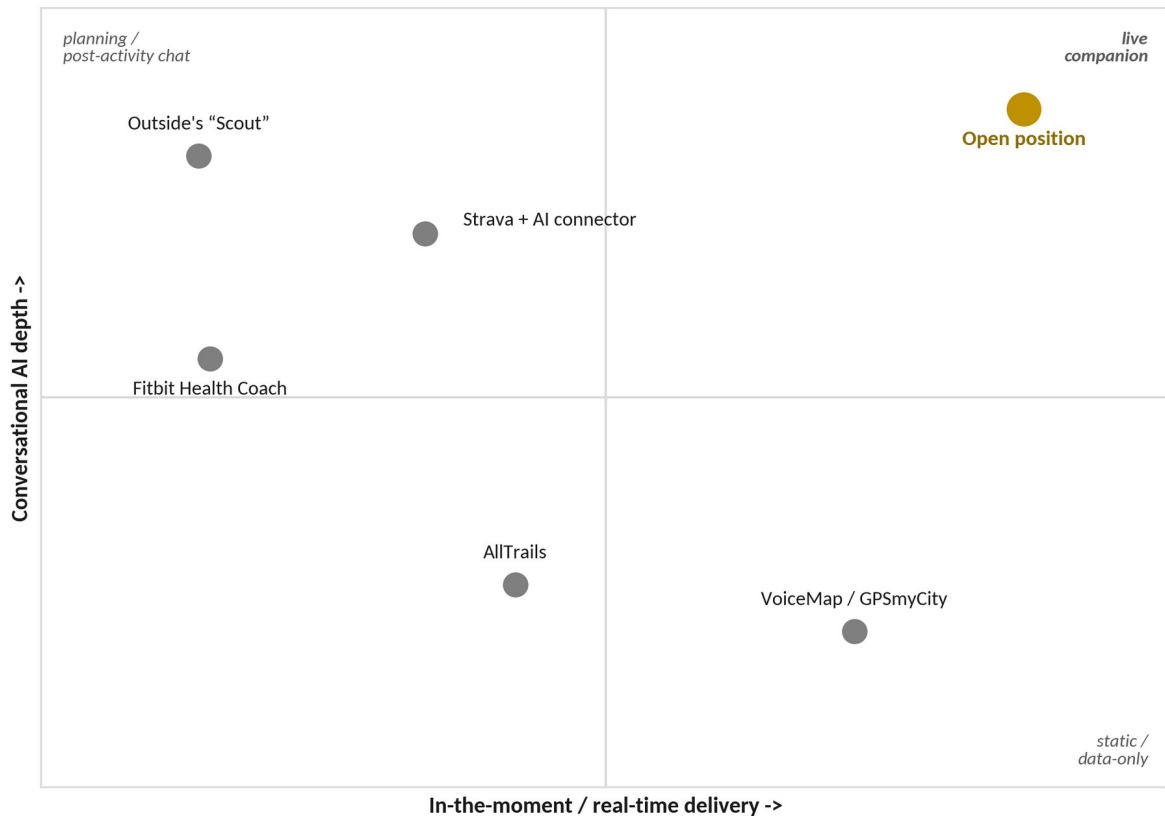


Figure 3. Positioning of the six platforms reviewed — real-time delivery vs. conversational AI depth. Not an exhaustive market map.

4.1 Synthesis

A notable pattern among the platforms reviewed: several major fitness and outdoor players have moved toward conversational AI within the last 12 months — Strava shipped a Claude-powered connector in June 2026, Fitbit is piloting an LLM coach, and outdoor publisher Outside built its own chatbot. That is a meaningful validation signal for

the category. But each has built the AI layer as a planner or analyst bookending the activity, not a presence during it. Based on the six competitors reviewed here, the live, in-the-moment position appears open — though a broader competitive scan may surface others we did not cover.^[13,14,17,18]

5. Primary Research

A 201-respondent user testing survey was fielded to check the secondary research directly against the target audience, using behavioral discovery questions (to surface pain points in respondents' own words before any concept was shown), a neutral concept reveal, individual feature-importance ratings against a proposed product roadmap, and Van Westendorp pricing questions.

5.1 Intent to use

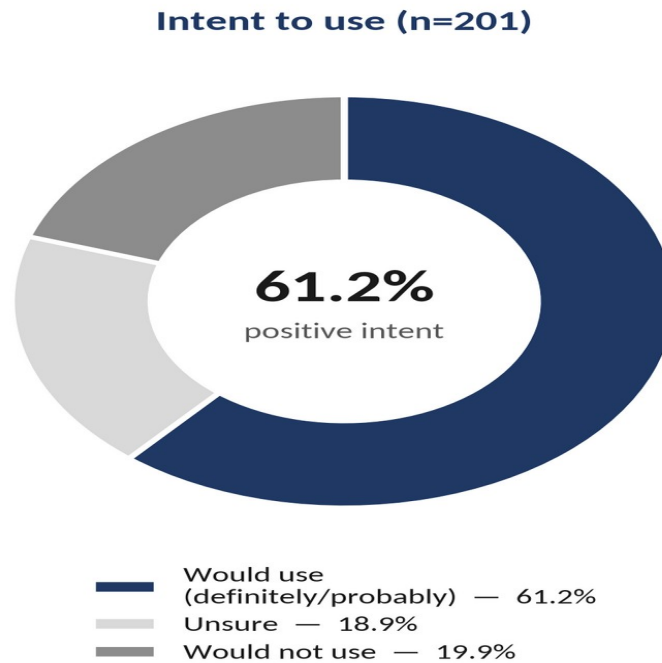


Figure 4. Stated intent to use a live voice-AI companion after a neutral concept reveal (n = 201).

61.2% of respondents said they would definitely or probably use such a product, against 19.9% who would not — roughly a 3:1 positive-to-negative ratio for a zero-awareness concept. The remaining 18.9% were unsure, which at this stage looks like a convertible group rather than a rejection.

5.2 Behavioral validation (the problem, in users' own words)

Metric	Result	What it validates
Explore alone or mostly alone	73.6%	The target audience is predominantly solo, matching the solo-travel market data
Feel curious about surroundings “often” / “almost every time”	51.7%	Curiosity is a frequent, recurring state — not an occasional impulse
Forget to look something up, or just keep moving	45.8%	Curiosity regularly goes unmet — the exact gap this product category closes
Feel uncertain, unmotivated, or anxious exploring somewhere new	50.7%	Validates the companion angle as a wellbeing feature, not just entertainment

5.3 Feature prioritization

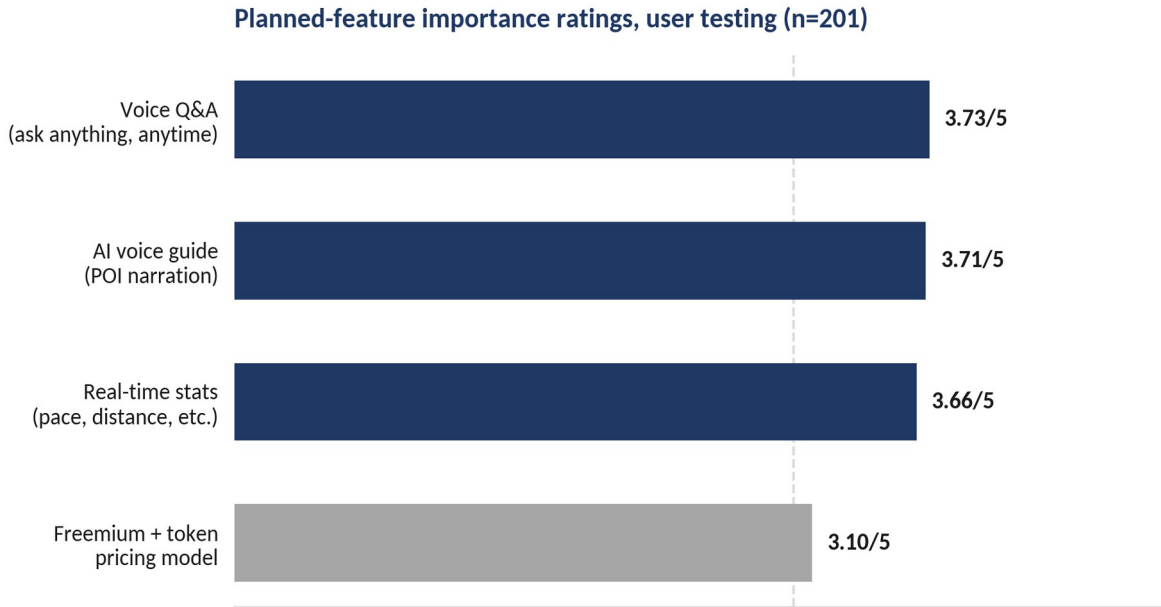


Figure 5. Importance ratings for planned features, 1–5 scale (n = 201).

Voice Q&A (3.73/5) narrowly edges out AI narration of points of interest (3.71/5) — a useful product signal: users want to be able to initiate conversation as much as receive narration, suggesting the roadmap should treat two-way conversational AI as core, not a layer on top of broadcast narration. Real-time stats (3.66/5) suggest fitness tracking is expected core value, not a nice-to-have. The freemium/token pricing model scored lowest (3.10/5) — expected, and arguably a healthy signal: it suggests people want the features enough to dislike limits, rather than rejecting the product outright.

5.4 Top user concerns (open-ended responses)

- Privacy / location tracking — echoed by the documented AllTrails default-public data exposure noted in Section 3.3; suggests privacy-forward positioning and minimal data retention should be a launch message, not an afterthought.^[6]
- Subscription cost — supports a generous free tier ahead of any paywall, consistent with the freemium-plus-token model already scoring lowest but not negatively.
- AI feeling robotic or inaccurate — a solvable product/voice-quality decision (e.g., natural voice synthesis) rather than a rejection of the concept.

6. Business Model Validation

The figures below are industry-wide benchmarks from RevenueCat's and Adapty's analyses of tens of thousands of apps — not projections specific to any single product. They're a useful reference point for the general direction (free tier + subscription/token hybrid over a pure subscription or hard paywall), but actual performance will depend heavily on execution, positioning, and market conditions at launch.

- AI-powered apps reach approximately \$0.63 in revenue-per-install (RPI) after 60 days in RevenueCat's dataset — roughly matching Health & Fitness, historically one of the highest-earning app categories — an effect RevenueCat attributes to generative features delivering value within the first minute of use.^[19]
- Roughly 35% of apps in RevenueCat's sample have shifted from pure subscriptions toward hybrid subscription-plus-token models, particularly in AI categories, with RevenueCat estimating 20–30% more revenue per user from charging high-frequency users for actual usage — directionally supportive of a free-minutes-plus-token-

purchase structure like the one considered here, though these figures describe the category rather than any single product.^[19]

- A commonly cited annual price range for fitness apps is \$49.99–\$79.99/year (or \$9.99–\$14.99/month), per Adapty's benchmark data — a reasonable anchor range to test against, though actual willingness-to-pay should be validated with further pricing research.^[21]
- Caution: RevenueCat reports roughly 31% more subscription apps launched in 2025 than 2024, while median monthly revenue per new app fell about 22% — rising competition means differentiation (the live-companion angle) and onboarding quality will likely matter more than category membership alone.^[19]

Conversion benchmarks relevant to a freemium+token model

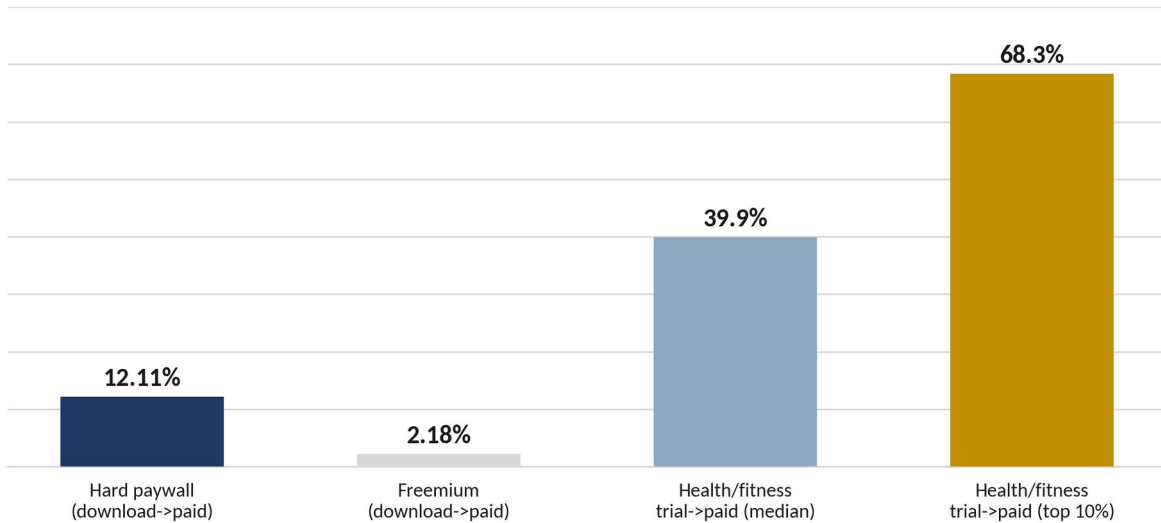


Figure 6. Conversion benchmarks relevant to a freemium-plus-token model. Source: RevenueCat 2025 State of Subscription Apps [19].

The gap between freemium (2.18% download-to-paid) and hard-paywall (12.11%) conversion is large in RevenueCat's data, but health & fitness trial-to-paid conversion (39.9% median, 68.3% for the top decile, per Athletech News' reporting on the same report) suggests that once users experience real value, this category can convert well — a reasonable argument that the free tier's job is to reach an “Aha Moment” quickly rather than to maximize free usage. These remain industry averages, not a guarantee of any single product's conversion rates.^[19,20]

7. Synthesis

Mapped against a standard market/problem/solution/timing framework, the evidence is mutually reinforcing rather than merely additive:

Market — Two large, independently growing markets overlap in this product category's use case — record outdoor participation (183.2M, +30M since 2019) and a voice-AI companion category growing 17–31% CAGR — with solo exploration as a fast-growing, currently under-served behavioral segment within both.

Problem — Participation is up but frequency is down — a motivation/engagement gap, not a demand gap — and users independently describe unmet curiosity (45.8%), regular anxiety exploring new places (50.7%), and loneliness/safety concerns (49% worry about loneliness; 64% of solo female travelers worry about safety).^[11,12]

Solution — Among the six platforms reviewed, none occupy the live, real-time, conversational quadrant. AllTrails and audio-tour apps are static; Strava, Fitbit, and Outside's Scout are conversational but only before or after the activity. Each platform reviewed has moved toward the category — just not from this specific angle.

Timing — Primary research is directionally consistent with the thesis — 61.2% positive intent on a cold concept, with feature ratings that map onto a plausible product roadmap (Voice Q&A and narration both >3.7/5) — while industry monetization benchmarks are broadly supportive of a hybrid pricing model like the one considered here.

A gap worth testing — Among the competitors reviewed, each has built AI for before or after the activity; none appear to have built it for during. That looks like an open position in the market — though it is based on a limited competitive scan and should be validated further before being treated as settled.

8. Risks & Open Questions

- Category crowding: RevenueCat reports subscription-app launches up roughly 31% year-over-year while median new-app revenue fell about 22% — differentiation and onboarding quality need to be strong from day one, not iterated in later.^[19]
- Trust is a live issue in this category: independent reporting on AllTrails' default-public location data shows how quickly location-based social features can generate negative sentiment — any new entrant should treat privacy-forward design as a core message, not a footnote.^[6]
- Voice quality is a stated risk: “feeling robotic” was a top-three open-ended concern — this is a product-quality bar to clear before wide launch, not just a marketing claim.
- This competitive scan covers six named platforms, not the full market; other players (regional apps, newer entrants, or unlaunched competitors) may occupy a similar position and were not captured here.
- On social sentiment: repeated search attempts did not surface reliable, permalinked Reddit or X (Twitter) posts for this revision. Section 3.2 should be updated with manually sourced, verbatim quotes before external publication.
- This survey (n = 201) is a first read but not yet segmented by age, gender, or activity type — a useful next cut, particularly given how differently senior and solo-female segments describe safety and motivation concerns in the secondary data.

9. References

Secondary research below was gathered via web search in July 2026 and cross-checked against original sources (company disclosures, press releases, and named market-research reports) rather than aggregator summaries where possible. Primary research is a 201-respondent user-testing survey fielded directly against this product category's target audience, structured as: screener → behavioral discovery → context/habits → neutral concept reveal → intent → individual feature ratings → Van Westendorp pricing → open-ended feedback → demographics. Verbatim Reddit and X (Twitter) threads could not be reliably retrieved through search despite repeated attempts; where social sentiment is discussed, this report notes the gap directly rather than filling it with fabricated quotes — see the Risks section for a sourcing recommendation.

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Figures in this report are illustrative visualizations of the statistics cited above; where secondary sources offered a range of estimates (e.g., voice AI companion market size), the report notes the range and charts the most frequently cited figure. Competitive and monetization claims throughout this report have been phrased to reflect the scope of the sources reviewed rather than as absolute, exhaustive statements.